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WRITING CRAFT

CLASS NOTES

The Dread Ladder: Escalating Psychological Tension Across a Story

Planning psychological dread before drafting

The core distinction

A disturbing event starts the problem. Escalation changes the conditions under which the character must understand and respond to that problem.

More bizarre incidents can increase intensity without moving the story. A strong dread beat changes the character's beliefs, available choices, personal cost, or trust in their own account.

The locked house

Nora inherits the house where a childhood fire drove her younger sister, Leah, away. After their mother dies, household objects begin returning to the positions they occupied on the night of the fire.

Nora decides Leah has entered the locked house. That explanation frightens her, but it also protects her. If Leah remains the threat, Nora does not need to question her own memory of the fire.

The protective interpretation

The character's wrong explanation should do more than mislead the reader. It should preserve an identity, memory, relationship, or belief the character feels unable to surrender.

Nora says Leah returned to punish her. The explanation protects Nora's certainty that she remembers the fire accurately. New evidence threatens a far worse possibility: Nora caused the fire and allowed Leah to carry the blame.

Four pressures of escalation

CERTAINTY

Coincidence becomes a pattern. The character grows more certain that something is wrong even when the cause remains unclear.

CHOICE

Safe responses disappear. Each decision changes what the character can still do next.

COST

Maintaining the protective explanation begins to damage relationships, safety, credibility, or the character's ability to retreat.

SELF-TRUST

Contradictions and omissions make the character question whether their own account can still guide them.

A major story turn should change at least one of these pressures.

The seven-rung dread ladder

1. Anomaly - Something disturbs the character's existing understanding.
2. Explanation - The character adopts an account that contains the threat and protects something important.
3. Contradiction - New evidence injures that explanation instead of merely adding another odd event.
4. Costly denial - Preserving the explanation now causes damage.
5. Complicity - The character begins helping to create or preserve the danger.
6. Collapse - Evidence makes the protective account unusable.
7. Recognition - The character understands the resisted truth and must choose what to do with it.

Nora's progression

The scorched serving dish appears on Nora's table. She explains it by deciding Leah entered the house. The alarm record and the dish's history contradict that theory.

Nora publicly accuses Leah, then hides evidence that weakens the accusation. Her attempt to remain psychologically safe now helps sustain the danger. An old recording finally makes her previous account of the fire impossible to maintain.

Solving who moved the objects provides the external answer. Recognition arrives when Nora understands why she needed the wrong answer.

Planning questions

- What new evidence appears?
- How does the character interpret it?
- What does that interpretation protect?
- What does maintaining it cost now?
- Which option disappears afterward?

If two consecutive beats produce the same answers, combine them or make the later beat change the story more substantially.

Main takeaway

Dread climbs when every major turn makes the character's old way of understanding the story harder and more costly to sustain.